

SHORT FICTION · FANTASY

The Power Brigade

Episodes One and Two

The Power Brigade

Episode One

The sun dropped behind the imperial box and cut the great arena of the Central City in two, one half gold, one half shadow. Under the open sky, the stands had filled to the top. Down below, on the sand churned up by the trials, only the fighters remained. They gathered in the middle, each with a sword at the hip or some other weapon, and they waited.

From the railing of the box, nine long lances had been set out, angled over the sand, and from each hung a new banner, high enough for a man to pass beneath it without touching it. Eight of them were blue as the sky and stitched with silver. The ninth was different, the only cloth with a thread of gold along its edge, raised a little higher than the rest. The whole arena knew the rule: to pass beneath a banner meant you had been chosen.

Next to the imperial box, the Oracle stepped forward, or rather an incarnation of It, a mask over the face and a long robe, holding a scroll in its hands. It raised a hand, and the arena fell silent.

“We live our lives telling stories. Some stories are about history and mistakes. Other stories are about the things we believe of the world and the lies we take for truth. But from today a new

set of stories begins. The Oracle has seen that our future starts here, with the Power Brigade: an elite team, created by the Golden Empire and its allies, made to move fast and with full freedom. Their mission is to save our Realm from a great cataclysm that will meet us in the days to come. There are nine banners here today. Each banner stands for the highest devotion to the Brigade's mission. After these three days of trials, we have our answer."

Xener burned with impatience. He was a young man, strong, with hair red as fire, and the journey from his mountain village to here, the center of the world, still felt like a dream. Even the points he had gathered over the last days of trials amazed him, and he wondered whether he would really be chosen. He had done rather well, by his own reckoning.

The Oracle unrolled the scroll and called out, always with the same formula: the name, and the points gathered across all the trials.

"Yeru. One hundred and twenty points."

Yeru broke from the group in the middle and crossed the sand. Under the first lance he stopped for a moment, then passed beneath the banner, and the shadow of the cloth slid across his face for the length of a single step. On the other side he turned to face the arena and stood there, the first man of the Brigade.

The crowd threw his name back at him like a wave breaking against the stands.

Xener looked down and noticed his clothes were a little scorched from the trials. From this evening on he wanted only one thing, and he wanted it so badly he felt it lodged in his throat like a swallow held too long: to hear his name called. As for the cloth with the golden thread, he had assumed it was for the best of them all. He had kept himself from thinking any further. He had sworn he would not run when he heard his name. That he would walk beneath the banners slowly, like a man who knows the place is his.

“Yaleo. One hundred and ten points.”

The giant, a mountain of a man tattooed all over, yet with a friendly look on his face, crossed the sand and stooped to fit beneath the banner, and the wave of cheering matched his size. Then Tenoct. Then Berach. Then the two women fighters who not long ago had fought each other to the death, and were now sisters. Then the young half demon, whose name the crowd cheered more quietly.

Before the second to last name, the Oracle glanced briefly toward the imperial box. From the sand, no one noticed.

“Raad. Ninety points.”

The eighth wave of applause broke and drew back. On the scroll, under the Oracle's finger, there were still lines left. The finger came down no further. One banner remained. But the scroll had begun to roll itself shut.

The Oracle turned toward the Emperor. Xener did not understand: the next place could have been his. The silence stretched over the arena, stretched over him, and only when the crowd began to murmur, and the murmur turned, head after head, toward the imperial box, did he too understand that the sound was not coming. The Emperor had risen.

"The ninth banner," he said, and his voice had no need to shout, "will be carried by my son, prince Agam."

That was all. The crowd began to cheer loudly, though somehow more timidly.

In the box, the prince rose slowly: black hair at the crown, gone white at the sides, his face unmoving. To Xener, that indifference seemed the most insolent thing he had ever seen.

The crowd murmured again, but the murmur tired quickly and settled, the way things settle when no one can change them anymore. The Oracle drew the scroll to its chest and took a step forward, ready to close the ceremony. The prince started toward the edge of the box.

In the middle of the sand, Xener stood with his thoughts spinning in his head, faster and faster: the lines still left on the scroll, his name uncalled, the cloth with the golden thread. He wanted to keep quiet. He held his mouth shut for exactly as long as a man holds his breath under water.

“I object!”

He heard his own voice before he understood that he was the one who had shouted. After that, things became very simple.

Later he did not remember deciding anything. He remembered the sand under his feet. The step. Another step. The line of fighters parting to make way. The guards jerking out from under the box and the Emperor’s hand, curious, that stopped them. His own voice, hoarse with smoke, climbed up into the box in his place:

“Everyone beneath a banner passed through the trials. Let him pass through them too. Otherwise that place is nothing but a cloth with a golden thread.”

A terrible silence fell. The Emperor looked down at him for a long moment. “Who are you?” he asked. There was no anger in his voice. He was weighing him.

“A man who wants to die doing something great,” he answered. “And who has nothing to lose except that wish.” He raised his

sword above his head. "Xener of Avgaria," he shouted, his eyes on the golden banner and on the Emperor.

His name rang out at last across the arena. He had called it himself.

The echo of the name rolled a while longer through the corners of the arena. Up at the edge of the box the prince stood, his face like stone, seemingly unimpressed. Xener turned toward it. "I challenge you to a duel."

His voice stayed hoarse with smoke, but it no longer shook. Only after that did the rest come. "Otherwise it is an insult to every fighter on this sand."

In the box, Agam let the challenge hang, as if it did not even deserve haste. Then he shrugged.

"Fine," a firm voice said. "If you beat me, I will give up the place. It is yours. And if not..." He sketched a smile for the first time and started down the steps of the box, in no hurry. He turned his head toward his father. "At least everyone will see why I never needed the trials."

Up above, the Emperor said nothing. He only opened his palm, curious, the way you release a die.

Xener drew back toward the middle of the arena to make room. The rest of the fighters had pressed themselves to the walls.

Agam stepped onto the sand and drew the sword at his hip. It was not yet dark: the sun had slipped behind the rim of the stands, but the light still held. Xener gripped the handle of his sword and noticed that his hands were shaking.

They stopped face to face and took each other's measure. It began.

They took a step to one side. Another. The sand creaked underfoot, and the stands went quiet row by row. Neither of them looked for an opening. Neither wanted a tactical fight: both wanted to strike the other with everything they had, ready to kill.

They moved at once. The swords slammed together, with a sound that filled the arena, and rebounded. Xener's arm went numb to the shoulder: Agam's blade was tens of times heavier than it looked.

Xener took the initiative and attacked fast. Once, twice, the combinations he had polished through every trial. Agam turned them all aside with short, almost bored movements, like a man half at play. A parry, a step, another parry. Nothing got through.

"I saw you in the arena," Agam said between two exchanges. "You are the boy with the flames, aren't you?" He pushed the blade aside, without effort. "What is it? Run out of fuel?"

The words landed exactly where they had been aimed. Xener thought of the scroll that had rolled shut over the unread lines, of his name left there, of the cloth with the golden thread, of the indifference in the box, and the anger came to him whole, clean, his own. His heart went warm, then hot. He screamed and let the emotion loose.

From his hands, along the steel, flames burst out. In an instant they wrapped both swords, and Agam tore himself back with one quick step, his first hurried step in the whole duel, right before the fire could catch his sleeve.

“Ahh, there it is.” Agam spun his sword and looked at the smoke rising off the edge. “So you know how to manifest your Anger. This magic suits you. You are very... fired up.”

Xener gritted his teeth and came at him again, fire and all. Agam stayed too calm, and his calm was more dangerous than any blow: between them lay a chasm of experience and power.

“But you are just an infant who has not yet learned to speak,” he said, slipping aside by half a step. “Do you want me to teach you something? At least you will die a little wiser.”

Xener wanted to fire an insult back. He did not allow himself. A cold thought slid in under the anger, thin as a draft under a door: if he pushed Agam too far, maybe Agam would use his

own Anger. And who knew how the anger of a man raised in a palace burned.

That thought cost him. The flames on the sword shrank, then guttered like a candle in a draft. He looked down at his hands.

“What... No. No!” he heard his own voice, desperate.

When he looked up, Agam was no longer in front of him. “You see,” came the voice from behind, “you do not know how to hold your focus when your emotions change.”

He turned, but too slowly. A strike from behind could be fatal. The fear was there, it had already climbed into his chest, whole. “Use the Fear and manifest. Raise a barrier behind you, a shield, anything, just to take the blow.” That was all he had time to think.

The fist caught him across the jaw and carried him a good two meters through the air, until the sand received him with a scrape. Pain pulsed through his whole body. The fire went out completely, and with it, the magic. A few gasps went up through the stands.

He got up with difficulty, the taste of sand in his mouth, and set himself on guard. Agam did not bother to come after him. He stayed planted on his feet, in the middle of the arena, and waved a hand for him to come closer.

“This lesson is free. As every practitioner of magic knows, we have four base emotions: Anger, Sadness, Joy and Fear. Each manifests differently and has its own role. To keep an effect active while your emotions shift, you have to hold that feeling at the back of your mind and repeat it again and again.” A thin, cold shimmer passed along his blade, nothing like fire. “But it seems you are already reaching the limits of what you can do.”

Xener rushed in again. This time he feinted. He lit the fire on his blade and let his whole body promise a strike from above, and Agam read the sword, the way he had read every one of his moves since the first clash. Only, at the last instant, Xener shifted his weight onto the other foot, let Agam’s edge pass by his ear, and drove a foot into his stomach. In the last moments before impact, the foot burst into flame and stamped the fire into his opponent’s body.

The blow pushed Agam two steps back. A hole with scorched edges was left in his coat, and through it his skin showed, a little red. Xener’s first hit. The stands screamed and cheered. The crowd was captivated. Xener smiled, his breath burning in his chest. “At least that: now I have probably made him angry.”

But Agam was smiling. He straightened and raised his arm to the wound.

He set his palm over the burn and closed his eyes, only for a moment. A moment was all he needed to remember every guard and every servant of the palace who said, when they thought he could not hear, that he did not take after his father. That he had much to learn. That they were worried. He opened his eyes. When he took his palm away, the skin was whole. No mark, no stain, as if nothing had happened.

A quiet murmur went up. Xener looked at the smooth skin and felt his stomach tighten. He had used his Sadness to heal himself. So quickly. Some warriors spend a lifetime trying to heal a scratch the size of a fingernail through a single manifestation, and he had done it in one breath. He had the best training in the empire, and probably an affinity for Sadness, the way Xener had one for Anger. Xener clung to the only good thing in it: if his main emotion was Sadness, then his Anger could not be just as strong.

Agam waited with a grin, half turned toward the box so his father could see him. He liked to put on a show. "Maybe you think Sadness is my specialty." He spread his arms. "Allow me to show you who I really am."

He raised a hand above his head and roared, and all the air in the arena stirred. The sand rose and lay back down in waves, circling him. Around his hand, out of the wind, a jagged wheel took shape, as wide as a man is tall, spinning with the hiss of a

scythe. He arced his arm and loosed the projectile, straight ahead.

“[Wind Cutter]!”

Xener had no time to grasp what he was seeing. “Barrier,” something screamed inside him, now, in front. Nothing came out. All he managed was to grip the sword harder. The wheel crashed into his blade with a howl, tore him off balance, bit through his guard into the flesh of his shoulder and ricocheted on, over him, straight toward the stands.

A gasp of terror, then a thud like an explosion sounded from where the wheel landed. Then, through the risen dust, a clear globe appeared, like crystal, arched over the front rows. Down at the edge of the arena, a woman with purple hair held her palm open to the sky, holding up the magic dome and shielding the onlookers.

Xener steadied himself, digging his feet deeper into the sand. The cut burned on his shoulder, the edges of his vision had melted away and he barely kept himself upright.

And Agam, for the first time since he had come down onto the sand, looked thrilled. And he did not wait a single second. He charged.

He came at him without a single pause, blow after blow, not leaving him one second to think. Xener parried on reflex, shorter and shorter, lower and lower. He tore himself back and put three steps of sand between them, and in the respite Agam deigned to grant him, he understood clearly, with a shame that hurt worse than his shoulder: there was no way he could win.

“I am ashamed,” he thought. “Is that what I feel? Wait. What do I feel? Shame is a compound emotion. I feel anger at myself, for putting myself in this on my own. Fear, of losing in front of everyone. Sadness, that I look weak. No. No, it is something deeper.”

He closed his eyes in the middle of the duel. And he was honest with himself, all the way. “Mother.”

The anger did not come from the banner. Nor from Agam. It came from here: she had died, and he had not been there to protect her. He had not been able to accept it for a single day since, and he did not accept it now either. “I was not there.”

For her there was nothing left he could do. Never, however long he lived. But the Realm was full of people who should have been protected by their sons, and there was no one. Wherever he arrived, he would arrive in time. He would make sure of it, he told himself. He would become everyone’s son if he had to.

This duty he gave himself, eyes closed, in the middle of the arena, the same way he had called his own name.

The air changed. The whole arena felt it in the same instant: the moisture vanished from everywhere at once, as if you had stepped into an oven. Cracked lips, dry eyes, hot skin.

Agam heard the stir in the stands and looked around, puzzled. Then he looked at Xener.

Xener stood hunched, head down and arms slack at his sides. And over his whole body, from the shoulders to the tips of his fingers, small flames lit, flames that did not burn him.

He breathed hard. He no longer defended himself against what he felt. He let himself feel all of it, all the way, there, in the middle of the arena, with the whole empire watching him.

“Brother, this one is insane,” said Berach, from under the banners. “Oh yes,” Yaleo answered, delighted. “He is one of mine.”

The small flames joined together. The air between the two shimmered as it does above a fire, and every step toward Xener felt like a forge door opened in your face. Agam gripped his sword and stopped smiling.

Xener lifted his head. It was as if a demon of fire were smiling at Agam and calling him closer, into a realm beyond, a realm of

endless pain.

The creature of fire leapt. Agam managed to hide behind his sword. It did him no good. The impact blasted him across half the arena, into the far wall. He struck hard and slid down into the sand.

He got up fast, ears ringing, already searching his mind for the lessons on the magic of Fear. In his whole life he had rarely had anything to feed it with. Not now either. But when he looked toward the middle of the arena, there was no one left to defeat.

The flames died out in the sand like footprints. In the middle of them, Xener had fallen face down and did not move again.



The stands burst into deafening cheers, as if a dam had broken. It had been a fight the likes of which had never been seen in the whole Oracle's Challenge.

Agam stayed by the wall, sword in hand, and heard none of it. He looked at the heap of scorched clothes in the middle of the sand.

“It is impossible. He had more power in that one emotion than he had ever seen in anyone. And from some country reject, no

less? A nobody from a mountain village no one has heard of, capable of that?”

Agam was confused.

He turned to look toward the box, sword still in hand, braced for the stone face he knew from home. But his father was laughing. The Emperor Exeron was laughing from ear to ear, in a way Agam had not seen him laugh in years, and that laughter hurt him worse than the wall. Agam frowned.

Xener opened his eyes with sparks drifting in the air above him, and a hand the size of a shovel slid under his shoulder. Yaleo lifted him up to sitting, unhurried, the way you lift a heavy sack.

“Easy, little brother,” the giant said. “You were not gone long. Just long enough to scare everyone.”

A soldier sounded a horn, and the arena settled little by little, until once more only the wind through the banners could be heard. The Emperor rose for the second time that evening. Every eye was already on him.

“I did not expect this day to give birth to such a fight,” he said.

He looked at his son. Then at the boy in the sand. “I like this kid.” He did not say it quietly.

“I hate him,” said Agam. He did not say it quietly either.

The Emperor's laughter drew into a smile. "Then we are agreed. The ninth banner you will both carry."

A second perfect silence fell over the arena. Agam took a step forward. "Father..."

"Half each," the Emperor went on, over him. "The first of the two of you to become useless to the brigade will be thrown out. Not by me. You will know it yourselves. That should motivate you both."

His smile faded completely at the end. He looked one by one at all those beneath the banners, and when he spoke again, he no longer spoke only to the two of them. "The Oracle chose you for a mission. It said that together, as a team, you can face what is coming. But nothing is guaranteed. You must do everything you can to defend the Realm."

He sat down.

Agam passed first beneath the banner with the golden thread, his face grim and his eyes dead. Then, leaning on Yaleo's arm, Xener passed under too. Slowly, as he had promised himself. Only, not on his own feet.

Above, the ninth banner stirred in the wind, full of grace and honor. Xener looked at the golden thread and it no longer seemed insolent to him, nor out of reach. It only seemed heavy.

He had won half a banner, a rival, and somewhere, in the future, something dreadful that he would have to face.

The Power Brigade

Episode Two

The Central City was a very advanced settlement, with a strong army and solid diplomacy with all the kingdoms around it. The Emperor Exeron ruled over the Golden Empire, inhabited mostly by humans, but on its streets you could also meet other races: elves, dwarves, giants, beastfolk and all manner of other magical creatures. The city was among the few places in the Realm where every race lived side by side, and it did so successfully, with no major conflict between them.

The day after the Oracle's Challenge, Xener was the last to walk into the council hall. He had slept longer than he would have liked: the fight in the arena had drained him completely.

The others were already gathered around a round table, and there was someone else with them.

"I am Ashkar, the former instructor of the Army," the man introduced himself. "The Emperor sent me to be your mentor and to advise you, in case you need anything."

A kind of rock covered his right eye and climbed toward his forehead and over his head, like a helmet. One look at him and you knew he had come through many battles.

Still, Ashkar encouraged them to organize themselves, since that was the best way to learn.

A silence settled over the room. No one wanted to take the initiative, because every one of them had come through the Oracle's Challenge and every one of them was strong enough to manage alone. That was probably the greatest disadvantage of an individual contest: it does not pick the people who know how to work as a team.

Agam raised his voice.

"I know more about the Oracle's Vision. I was in the throne room when the Oracle informed my father. A great danger stalks the Realm, and the Oracle searched desperately for a solution in the Sea of Dreams: it searched for a world in which that evil is defeated. In that world, nine heroes, chosen in the Central City, fight together and defeat the supreme evil." He stopped for a moment. "Yesterday, my father allowed ten people to be chosen. I think we may have lost the chance to reach that future. We have already gone off course."

"The Oracle's visions are not written in stone," Ashkar said.

"Almost always, the Oracle expects its revelation to change the course of time and lead to new events. What you need to do now is work out where to begin the search. And you have very little information."

A guard interrupted the round table with a message for “the Power Brigade”. They were all surprised. Some kind of robbery had happened near the Great Market: a merchant’s house had been destroyed, and among the rubble a tablet had been found with a message addressed to the Brigade: “I know what you need. Catch me if you are worthy.”

They all set out to see it with their own eyes. Only Xener was held back by Ashkar: he needed his help with something. Elnatis said he was not interested in taking part. The others shrugged and let him go off to his room.

On the way, Yaleo saw women dressed in white, up on tall pillars scattered through the streets of the city. They seemed to be praying. When he came near them, he felt a sharp sound in his ears and asked the others if they knew what those were.

“They are the clerics of the Silent Goddess,” Raad answered.

“They stay up on the pillars and pray, and around them a field is held that dulls and blocks the emotions of the citizens. If you entered the Liquid State, you could see it. They say it is for the better running of the city.” He threw another look their way.

“Most likely they are praying to a false deity. Lost creatures. Only my god, Leytis, is real. The rest of the gods are things people made up.”

Yaleo did not contradict him. He was not especially a religious being. He only wondered why farmers pray to Psok, the god of the harvest, and mothers to Neyva, the goddess of families.

Once they arrived, they understood why the merchant's building had been described so strangely as "destroyed". Half the building had vanished perfectly, without a trace, leaving spherical shapes missing from the walls, from the floors and from the paved path in front of the house. The merchant Ilvan, who lived there, was reported missing, along with his family.

"Hey, grandpa, did you see what happened to the merchant Ilvan?" Lena asked another merchant who had a stall nearby.

"Grandpa??? The impertinence, I am fifty years old, I cannot believe this. Yes, well... I do not look the way I used to, do I?" he said, disappointed. "Ilvan? Do not talk to me about Ilvan. He will not leave me in peace even dead. He was always stealing my customers and boasting that his goods were better."

Lena laughed, embarrassed.

"Forgive Ringa," said a young girl who seemed to be his daughter. "He has been friends with Ilvan for some time and I think it has affected him. Though my father never shows his emotions."

Rummaging out of curiosity under some fallen boards near the house, Berach found a strange coin on the ground. Pacina saw him and came closer.

“What is that?”

“It looks like some kind of coin,” Berach said. “Only this coin does not exist.” He bit into it. “And it is made of a strange material. It looks like gold, but at the same time it has an odd shimmer, reddish.”

Pacina waited, thinking, and looked up at the “cut out” house. Berach followed her eyes and stood up.

“Most likely it is someone’s ability.”

Pacina nodded.

“Yes, only it is a horrifying ability... Most likely a person like that made this ability of theirs to wipe out places and people completely, in an instant.”

“It might not be that simple,” Tenoct said. He had black eyes and many ornaments in his ears and on his skin, piercing through it, a mark of his tribe. Most likely they still followed ancient gods, from before the Age of Magic. “If the emotion is strong enough, the effect of an ability can be amplified hundreds of times. Even someone with a simple ability, the

kind that makes small objects disappear, the size of an orange, could reach destruction like this with a very intense emotion.”

“But should that not be something out of the ordinary? Can a person have an emotion that strong?”

Tenocht paused.

“No. Not normally...”

“Team, over here!” Lena called from beside a very, very small vendor from the beastfolk clan. She had fur on her skin and pointed ears: she looked like a sort of raccoon.

“She says she heard arguing last night,” Lena told them when they came over. “And then some individuals with masks and knives, leaving the place with sacks.”

“Most likely some Thieves Below,” Agam said. “They raid inside the city often and pull back underground, through forgotten sewers where the Royal Army cannot get in.”

“Everyone, out of the way!” Pacina shouted.

She put her fist on the ground and breathed out. She focused on the first puppy her mother ever gave her: she had been so happy then, she still remembered the black, sweet eyes Spot had when he was only a small pup. From her fist a circle spread out, full of

signs and runes that moved across the cobbles of the path, and out of the circle a wolf began to rise, as big as a man.

“Spot, get to work!”

The wolf rushed at the spot Pacina pointed out and began to sniff.

The gang was impressed: she had caught on very fast and acted. They had all seen Pacina’s purple beasts in the arena already, but it surprised them how easy she was with her magic. She was probably very proud of it.



Back at the castle, Xener sat at a desk in the Living Library of the palace, writing away. Ashkar came up to him.

“Let us see, young man, what you have written.”

Xener handed him the sheet, bored. Ashkar read for a few moments and looked the page up and down.

“Unfortunately, this is not good, young Xener. Start again. Imagine a painful moment from your life, write it on the sheet and then throw the sheet away. Then start writing a story on a new sheet.”

“I have already done that three times. What is this, some kind of torture? I was only a few moments late.”

Ashkar smiled.

“It is not a punishment at all. In fact, it is training. I cannot say more. Now try again, you will work it out on your own.”

Xener looked after Ashkar, confused, as he opened the tall door of the library and left the room.



Down below, the Power Brigade was going through a real test of humility: crouched over, they were crawling through a tiny tunnel, following the glowing purple wolf that kept sniffing out the scent of the thieves.

They reached the mouth of a tunnel and climbed down into a kind of enormous chamber, held up by stone columns and connected by tunnels on every side.

“I did not even know this was here,” Agam said. “It must be part of the old city. Every Emperor rebuilt the Central City almost from scratch when he took the throne. There must be five or six cities set one on top of the other here.”

“It seems we are not alone here,” Yaleo said, and pointed at some tents pitched in the middle.

The team crossed the middle of the chamber and looked at a kind of black market spread out underground. Meat of dubious origin, stolen chandeliers, knives, everything. The citizens of Below were no prettier themselves: they either had an eye missing, or they were crippled or covered in boils, or they were sharpening their knives at the new prey walking free through their streets.

“This place gives me the creeps,” Lena said.

The group went on and entered one of the side tunnels, until they reached a crossing with four other ways.

“It seems they split up here,” Pacina said, watching the wolf circling, confused about which way to take.

“Well, what are we waiting for? First one to find the thieves wins!” Yaleo said, and broke into a run down one of the tunnels.

“Wait, what are you doing? Do we not need a plan?” Berach shouted.

But it was too late. Lena and Pacina ran off one way, Raad followed Yaleo, Tenoct left alone down another tunnel, and only Berach, Agam and Yeru were left.

“There is no one to talk to yet,” Yeru said to Agam.

Agam made to leave down the remaining tunnel as well, but Yeru stopped him.

“Wait a moment, your grace. We might be needed here.”

Berach looked at Yeru, curious, but decided to wait as well.



Raad and Yaleo arrived in a kind of underground temple, where the water of the sewer soaked the floors.

“What is this place?” Yaleo asked.

“Do you really know nothing about the Central City?” Raad said, annoyed. “What, did you live in the mountains?”

“Yes, I did live in the mountains,” Yaleo said. “That is where my clan is from. Was from, actually. I am the last survivor.”

Raad went quiet.

“I have a bad feeling,” Yaleo said.

“You are right, I feel it too. This place looks like a temple of the God of the Horizon. His temples used to be brighter than this. This one seems desecrated somehow.”

Out of the water two hulking shapes of black tar rose up and attacked them.

Both went into close combat with the two of them. Yaleo was impressed that Raad, who was smaller and looked more fragile, threw himself into fighting up close. Only, his fists kept getting stuck in the tar, and he realized their powers were not a good match: the fact that both of them fought at close range was a disadvantage. Raad had no more success either. He fought with open palms, channeling his Sadness, and shouted:

“[Ensouled Release]!”

He felt a resistance on the other side and felt it scatter, exactly as it does with people. He realized that most likely they were dealing with human spirits. Slowly, slowly, the two of them were taken by the tar and sank into it, as into a deep sleep.



The two women went down some steps and entered deeper into a dark tunnel. They saw a light at the end of it. When they came closer, they saw something bent over a bloodied body. The creature turned quickly when it felt it had been seen: a beastman with the face of a tiger, feeding on a corpse by the light of a campfire. The moment he saw them, he called out, delighted, that his prey had come to him.

He drew the claws out of his hands and rushed at the two of them. Pacina signaled the wolf to attack and gave it an automatic command: "Strike everything that is an enemy." That command could be overwritten or cancelled at any time, as long as Pacina could make a hand signal to the wolf. Lena pushed her cloak aside and revealed a series of bows fixed on her forearms, on her hips, on her palms, on her legs, effectively everywhere.

The tiger made a leap over Pacina's wolf, touched its back with his palm and threw himself toward the girls. Pacina gritted her teeth at how easily her companion had been ignored. Lena brought her hands close to her body and pulled several cables, hard, until she heard the material creak from the tension. In the bows, three arrows appeared on each cable she pulled.

"My creation, [Translucent Arrows]!"

She wanted to see the surprise on the attacker's face when her arrows hit him. Instead, she heard a short, high scream coming from somewhere else. When she looked properly, in the direction she had fired stood Pacina, who had now fallen, pierced by the arrows.

"Pacina?"

"Lena, you hit me!"

Lena froze.

* * *

Raad was sinking slowly into the tar and had almost no air left to breathe. Even so, he ignored the spasms of his body and listened carefully, in case he could hear a voice. And at last he heard it: “Nooo, not our temple...” Raad imagined that he was speaking and sent out: “What do you feel?” After a hesitation, the voice answered: “I am sad.” “Why?” “Because the temple is not beautiful anymore.” “No,” Raad answered firmly. “Say it about yourself.” “Because I do not have a beautiful temple anymore.” “Good. Why?” “Because I worked very hard to make it beautiful.” “I see. And what do you need?” “To be appreciated for doing good work.”

The tar began to grow less thick, and Raad felt himself come free and felt it fall away from him. He pulled back and breathed deeply. At the same time, the tar on Yaleo began to go as well.

“You did good work,” Raad said.

The tar began to fall faster and to dissolve, dropping like tears into the water. The two creatures vanished completely.

“Phew, what was that?” Yaleo said. “For a moment I thought it was over.”

“They were probably the souls of devout architects who stayed here, underground, when this area was closed off.”

Yaleo looked at him, confused.

“I am glad I am not like them, lost,” Raad said, and turned his back. “Let us go back. It is a dead end this way. Most likely the thieves set a trap for us to follow them down this path, and they turned back through the same tunnel and took another way.”



Like the others, Tenoct was in a trap too. A giant centipede now surrounded him from every side, attacking with its legs from the directions he did not expect.

“This is bad. It has me from all sides, and [Esoteric Hand] has no effect.”

Tenoct had the ability to summon one or more translucent hands, to strike the enemy from a distance or from behind. Even so, the centipede had a very hard shell and nothing he tried seemed to have any effect. He had already been stung by one of its hundreds of legs and he did not want to find out what it is like to be pierced by a hundred needles at the same time.

“Tenoct, lift it!” came from somewhere in the dark.

The centipede stopped for a moment and turned its head. The voice seemed familiar. Tenoct understood immediately who it was. After all, he had seen yesterday what destructive power his attacks had.

He summoned two Esoteric Hands and gripped the edges of the shell, in the area the voice had come from. The centipede felt itself being lifted and tried to writhe free.

But it was too late.

“[Wind Cutter]!”

The jagged wheel slipped in at exactly the perfect angle, tilted by Tenoct, under which it could get beneath the shell and tear the guts out of the giant insect.



“What is happening?” Lena repeated once more, her voice shaking and her eyes fixed on Pacina’s wounds.

“Lena, get a hold of yourself, I am fine,” Pacina said, pulling an arrow out of her shoulder and throwing it away. “Better think about what ability he has.”

The tiger man, who was near Pacina, came closer and struck at her with his claws, and she got clear only just in time. Still in

mid leap backward, Pacina signaled with one hand for the wolf to attack the enemy in front of her. She had deactivated her automatic command from the moment she realized Lena's attack made no sense, and now she had to control it manually, at every gesture, without knowing what the enemy's ability was and when it was safe to attack.

The tiger man parried, pushed the wolf aside and sprinted toward Lena. Still processing what was happening, she barely had time to raise her hands crossed, into a guard. The tiger man pushed her with an outstretched hand into the wall of the tunnel and jumped aside in time, before the wolf's fangs could catch him.

Pacina had a moment when she thought she understood what their enemy was doing, but it was too risky a thing to try, so she made a signal to her wolf, and it leapt again.

"Wait, Pacina!" a voice came suddenly from the tunnel.

That was all she had needed. She understood immediately. At the last instant she changed the position of her wrist and pointed at Lena. The wolf turned and bit deep into the girl's abdomen.

But in the next second the two of them saw the tiger's belly spray blood, and he dropped to his knees.

“His ability was to swap where we saw him with the person he touched with his palm, was it not?” Pacina asked the young man coming out of the dark.

Berach nodded.

“Lena, are you all right?” he asked.

Lena tore herself out of her daze, staring at the tiger man, and started back down the corridor, determined.

“Let us go,” she said, sulking.

* * *

Back in the corridor, Yeru saw Tenoct and Agam coming back. He gave them a small nod and waited. Slowly footsteps were heard, and Yaleo and Raad came out of the shadow of the tunnel. Pacina, Lena and Berach came back too, a short while after.

Yeru waited to see what reactions they all had, but the great majority were looking at the ground or waiting, deep in thought.

“This is not the time to lose ourselves in regrets and stories about what we could have done better. We came here for a

reason, and we have to keep going. I suggest you let out now what you feel.”

For a moment, no one reacted. But Yeru was right. Better now than to risk an emotion breaking out later on.

Yaleo started first. He tensed his whole body and roared with everything he had:

“I threw myself at the enemy like an idiot!”

Tenoc waited for him to finish and shuddered, closing his eyes.

“Brrr. I could have died there, when I let myself get surrounded.”

Lena began to cry. She did not have the strength to say more, but Pacina took her in her arms and stroked her back.

After each of them had finished with their own, Yeru turned his back and set off toward the tunnel they had not searched.

“Let us go.”

* * *

Xener did not understand what Ashkar wanted from him. He had written it five times or so, five painful episodes from his life, and after each one Ashkar told him to write a story. But every

time he told him it was not good. He looked closer and read them again. Yes, he had done exactly what he was supposed to: five painful moments, now turned into stories. They had exactly the same atmosphere. He had written about when he found out his father was not coming back, and he had written a story about a hero abandoned by his father. He had written about when he was frightened in the forest when he saw a lost goblin, and he had turned it into a story about fearsome creatures in the forest. What else did he want?

Unless... Xener started a new sheet. He had an idea.

* * *

The Brigade went through mysterious tunnels and chambers and reached, in the end, the den of a band of thieves. All through the lair lay stolen goods: chandeliers, rolls of cloth, weapons, sacks of gold thrown in heaps. The thieves were busy sharpening knives or dividing up the loot, but when the gang walked in among them, they only stared, without interrupting what they were doing.

“They are confident enough in their powers if it does not bother them that strangers have walked into their lair,” Berach thought.

“Did you rob the merchant Ilvan’s shop?” Yaleo asked the chief of the thieves.

The chief was dressed in black clothes, with a hood and a mask. You could tell only from his eyes that he was laughing under it.

“No.”

“Then why do you have these coins next to you?” Berach said, and pointed at a sack of coins lying open next to another heap of sacks of gold. Out of it spilled the same gold with the reddish shimmer.

The chief shrugged.

“Fine, we did take the gold, true. But only because it happened to be scattered everywhere. We only heard two old men arguing and we came. We did nothing more.”

“I do not believe you,” Berach said, angry.

For a moment, everyone went on guard. The thieves began to get up as well and draw their knives. The chief sighed.

“Fine. You started a fight, not us.”

He raised his hand, and everyone in the Brigade who had a sword felt it begin to tremble slowly and try to turn against them.

“Wait!” Pacina shouted at him. “Is the ability that wipes objects out of existence not yours?”

The chief stopped. A long pause fell.

“Wipe objects out of existence?” he said at last, and the laughter showed in his eyes again. “If I could do something like that, do you think I would still be living in a sewer?”

He lowered his hand, and the swords settled.

“My men heard two old men arguing louder and louder. Then a light, then quiet. When they got there, half the house was gone, and the gold was scattered everywhere. That is all.”

Berach looked at Pacina. They both thought the same thing: of the merchant who was always arguing with Ilvan and who never showed his emotions.

* * *

The old man sat down on a crate of goods, wiping his sweat and trying to light his pipe. A hand helped him light it, and he drew on it. Then Berach sat down on a crate as well.

“Do you know what you did to Ilvan?”

The old man frowned at him, confused. Then he raised his eyelids and looked down.

“So it is true.”

A pause.

“Yes,” Berach said. “Did you want to do it?”

“If I tell you I do not know anymore, honestly, I would not believe myself either.”

“What happened?”

The old man drew on his pipe. He breathed out deeply.

“We had been arguing, for the tenth time that day, like every day. Only this time he told me he had had enough and that he was moving his shop somewhere else. That he had put up with me all these years for nothing.” He paused. “I was lost. I was furious. When I came back to myself, I saw everything in front of me turning into gold coins. I hid in the house,” the old man sighed.

Berach said nothing.

“He was probably the person I had known the longest. Funny enough, I think I spent more time with him than with my wife. But she died when my daughter was born, so...”

Berach waited.

“And what do you feel?”

The old man looked into the distance and seemed to be struggling somehow.

“I think... sadness, but I do not know.”

Berach stood up and made a sign to the two soldiers of the Royal Army who were waiting.

“Let yourself cry, old Ringa.”



Back at the castle, Xener showed Ashkar the story he had made, and Ashkar nodded.

“At last, master Xener. Now you understand that you can use your emotions to create something new. It does not have to be the same emotion every time that gives you the effect you need. This lesson will serve you well from now on, when you learn to sublimate your emotions.”

Just then the rest of the brigade came into the room, looking rather sad. Xener asked them if they had found anything.

“An old vendor, a friend of the missing merchant,” Berach said.

“Because of the dampening from the clerics of the Silent Goddess, which he was exposed to constantly, he did not show his emotions for thirty years. Last night, in an argument, they

all poured out at once. He probably made the ability unconsciously, on the spot, wishing for a power that would turn everything in his way into gold coins. That is how half a house and his friend disappeared, family and all. And then the thieves stole the coins.”

Xener was left a bit stunned. It had been far more complicated than he expected.

“So... and what happened to the old man?” he asked.

“For the moment, he is being helped to understand his emotions again,” Berach said. “Even so, he will most likely stay in prison for a while.”

After the quiet had settled, Raad asked:

“Still, what about the message we got?”

“Ah, that one was mine,” Ashkar said. “I slipped it in among the ruins this morning, to see how you would manage working as a team.”

There was a lot of swearing, laughing and protesting. But in the end, they all appreciated Ashkar.